# FOURTH SUIT FORCING

## ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

Although it is not a part of the Deals you might wish to examine your and dummy's hand and make a Plan of how you would play the contract.

## FOURTH SUIT FORCING SUMMARY

This is a bad name for a good convention. It's bad because probably every Bridge player in the world plays that a bid of the fourth suit by their partner is already forcing. As a matter of history, the convention was originally called "Fourth Suit Artificial", but the name didn't stick. So we will call it Fourth Suit Forcing (FSF) but in reality it is FOURTH SUIT FORCING AND ARTIFICIAL.

> A bid by Responder, at his second turn, of the fourth suit is artificial and is made when no other reasonable bid is available. It is forcing and Opener is asked to further describe his hand.

While everybody plays the bid as forcing, there is not a universal agreement of what it is forcing to! Many partnerships play the bid as forcing to game, many others play it as forcing for one round, but merely invitational to game. Of course you will do as you like, but for the purposes of these practice Deals we will play it as a one-round-force which is invitational to game, about 12 points or more.

In many ways FSF is similar to the New Minor Forcing convention, and we suggest that you play the two conventions with the same forcing principle, just for consistency.

| Pard | You |
|---|---|
| 1♣ | 1♥ |
| 1♠ | 2♦ |

Your 2♦ bid is forcing and definitely does not show a ♦ suit. After your side has bid three suits the chances of finding an 8-card fit in the fourth suit is practically zero. If you really had a ♦ suit you would surely just bid notrump at your second turn.
So this is FSF and your hand might be:
♠ Q 9 5 ♥ A K J 7 4 ♦ 10 7 3 ♣ A 2

You cannot support either of partner's suits, you cannot rebid your ♥s, and you cannot bid notrump with no ♦ stopper. But you have 15 points and partner has opened, so you have to find some bid! Aha! Bid FSF and await partner's next bid.

**Requirements for FSF:** As we have said, Responder needs a minimum of 12 points; a hand that is at least invitational. More often than not Responder will have enough strength to insist on game, but not know which game to bid. There are two types of hand that benefit most from FSF.

When Responder has a notrump type hand but doesn't have a stopper in the fourth suit he can use FSF.

| Pard | You |
|---|---|
| 1♦ | 1♠ |
| 2♣ | ?? |

♠ K Q J 4 ♥ 10 8 4 ♦ K 7 ♣ A J 9 6

With 14 points you know you want to reach game. You could just bid 3NT and hope partner has a ♥ stopper but that might turn out very embarassing. You can't bid 3♣ because partner would probably pass. And if you jump to 4♣ you have bypassed 3NT, which might well be your best game. So you bid 2♥ and force partner to bid again.

When Responder's first suit is a 5-card Major he can use FSF to get partner show 3-card support.

| Pard | You |
|---|---|
| 1♣ | 1♥ |
| 1♠ | ?? |

♠ K 6 4 ♥ A K 10 8 4 ♦ 8 7 ♣ K 10 6

With 14 points you know you want to reach game. You cannot support either of partner's suits, you can't rebid a 5-card ♥ suit, and you certainly can't bid notrump. So you bid 2♦ (FSF) and see what partner has to say. If he has 3 ♥s he will return to that suit and you can bid the game. Or, he might bid notrump himself.

Besides these two main purposes you can use FSF whenever you want to make a forcing bid but don't like your other choices.

**Opener's rebid after FSF:**

Here are Opener's recommended rebids, listed in order of priority:

1. Rebid his own second suit if 5-5 or better.
2. Support partner's first suit with 3 cards.
3. Bid 2NT with a stopper in the fourth suit and a minimum.
4. Bid 3NT with a stopper in the fourth suit and a maximum.
5. Raise the fourth suit with 4-cards, but don't bypass 3NT (rare).
6. Rebid a 5-card suit if no other bid can be made.

| You | Pard | |
|---|---|---|
| 1♥ | 1♠ | ♠ 7 ♥ A Q 10 8 4 ♦ 8 5 ♣ A K 7 5 3 |
| 2♣ | 2♦ | Bid 3♣ to show a 2-suiter. |
| ?? | | |

| You | Pard | |
|---|---|---|
| 1♣ | 1♥ | ♠ A 10 6 4 ♥ K 8 4 ♦ 8 5 ♣ A Q 10 6 |
| 1♠ | 2♦ | Bid 2♥ to show 3-card support. |
| ?? | | |

| You | Pard | |
|---|---|---|
| 1♣ | 1♥ | ♠ A 10 6 4 ♥ 8 4 ♦ A Q 5 ♣ K J 10 6 |
| 1♠ | 2♦ | Bid 3NT to show maximum with a ♦ stopper. |
| ?? | | |

| You | Pard | |
|---|---|---|
| 1♦ | 1♥ | ♠ A J 6 4 ♥ 4 ♦ A Q 8 3 ♣ Q J 7 5 |
| 1♠ | 2♣ | Bid 3♣ with 4 of the suit. |
| ?? | | |

| You | Pard | |
|---|---|---|
| 1♦ | 1♠ | ♠ A 4 ♥ 9 4 ♦ A Q 8 4 3 ♣ Q J 7 5 |
| 2♣ | 2♥ | Bid 3♦ because you have no other bid. |
| ?? | | |

**Odds and ends:**

*If either partner is a passed hand, FSF does not apply.*

*If the opponents interfere you should play that FSF is off.*

*There is one special case where a bid of the fourth suit is not FSF.*

| Pard | You | |
|---|---|---|
| 1♣ | 1♦ | Only in this bidding sequence is the fourth suit not FSF. |
| 1♥ | 1♠ | The bid is forcing, but shows a real ♠ suit. |

14 examples will be worth more than another 14000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣K

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦3

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥K

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣8

***Board 1***
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 3
♥ A Q J 7 2
♦ Q 10 8 3
♣ 6 4

♠ 9 7 4 2
♥ 9
♦ J 9 5 4
♣ A 10 8 2




♠ 10 8 6
♥ K 10 5 3
♦ 6 2
♣ K Q J 3

♠ K Q J 5
♥ 8 6 4
♦ A K 7
♣ 9 7 5

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 1♥ | Pass | 1♠ |
| Pass | 2♦ | Pass | 4♥ |
| All Pass | | | |

4♥ by North
Lead: ♣K

You have a totally square 13 points. Still, you don't want to ignore a 4-card ♠ suit so you respond 1♠. Partner rebids 2♦. What do you say next?

You COULD bid 3♣, FSF, to find out if partner has a ♣ stopper but that would be pointless. You already know of an 8-card ♥ fit so you say 4♥.

***Board 2***
West Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A 9 8 5<br>♥ J 10 8 5<br>♦ Q 5 4<br>♣ J 8 | |
| ♠ 7 4 3<br>♥ K 2<br>♦ K J 10 8<br>♣ A Q 9 6 |  | ♠ K Q J 6 2<br>♥ 9 6 3<br>♦ A 6<br>♣ K 5 4 |
| | ♠ 10<br>♥ A Q 7 4<br>♦ 9 7 3 2<br>♣ 10 7 3 2 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1♦ | Pass | 1♠ | Pass |
| 2♣ | Pass | 2♥ | Pass |
| 2♠ | Pass | 4♠ | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♠ by East
Lead: ♦3

With both 4-card minors you open 1♦. Partner responds 1♠.

You cannot support ♠s with only 3 of them. Instead you bid 2♣. Partner says 2♥.

This is FSF, asking you to further describe your hand, and you have a problem. You do have a ♥ stopper so you COULD bid 2NT. You also have 3 ♠s so you COULD bid 2♠. Either way might turn out best, but that ♥K looks pretty lonesome so you choose 2♠ and partner raises to 4♠.

***Board 3***
South Deals
E-W Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 9 7 5<br>♥ 6 3<br>♦ K 10<br>♣ A K Q J 8 3 | |
| ♠ 10 8 6<br>♥ A K J<br>♦ 8 4 2<br>♣ 10 7 5 2 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ A Q 4 2<br>♥ 8 4 2<br>♦ J 7 5 3<br>♣ 9 4 |
| | ♠ K J 3<br>♥ Q 10 9 7 5<br>♦ A Q 9 6<br>♣ 6 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1♥ |
| Pass | 2♣ | Pass | 2♦ |
| Pass | 2♠ | Pass | 2NT |
| Pass | 3NT | | |
| All Pass | | | |

3NT by South
Lead: ♥K

You respond 2♣. Partner rebids 2♦. What is your next bid?

With 13 HCP and that ♣ suit you could jump to 4♣. However, that would sail you right past 3NT which is very likely to turn out your best game. Rather than rebid ♣s, find out whether partner has ♠s stopped by using FSF.

You bid 2♠ and partner then says 2NT. Where do you go from here?

It couldn't have worked out better. Notrump played from partner's side. You bid 3NT.

***Board 4***
East Deals
Both Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ J 10 7 2<br>♥ Q 9 6 2<br>♦ K 10 2<br>♣ 8 7 | |
| ♠ K Q 9 5<br>♥ K 3<br>♦ A J 8 6 3<br>♣ 9 3 |  | ♠ A 8 6 3<br>♥ A J 7 5<br>♦ 9<br>♣ K Q 6 4 |
| | ♠ 4<br>♥ 10 8 4<br>♦ Q 7 5 4<br>♣ A J 10 5 2 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1♣ | Pass |
| 1♦ | Pass | 1♥ | Pass |
| 1♠ | Pass | 2♠ | Pass |
| 4♠ | | | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♠ by West
Lead: ♣8

There is only one possibility; you open 1♣. Partner responds 1♦.

You rebid "up-the-line", so you now say 1♥. Partner says 1♠.

Be careful! This is NOT Fourth Suit Forcing. It is true that you are forced to bid, but the difference is that in this sequence partner has a real ♠ suit. With 4-card support you bid 2♠ and partner raises to 4♠.